



JULY 21, 2005 Four immigrants of African origin conducted unsuccessful attacks on London's transport system and were convicted



JULY 7, 2005 The scene after a bus explosion in London. An hour earlier, three bombs exploded on the Underground. Fifty-two were killed and 770 injured.



REUTERS/LUKE MACGREGOR

made out of liquids carried in ordinary containers. Again, there are alleged links to networks in Pakistan. Then there was Dhiren Bharot, an Indian-born Hindu convert to Islam, radicalised through involvement in Kashmir, who was sentenced late last year—a 'one-man band' with connections to the top of the Al Qaeda hierarchy. There were also the so-called Ammonium Nitrate bombers, a group of young men, mainly British Pakistanis, arrested in the spring of 2004 and named after the 600 kg of makeshift explosives they had assembled in a storage facility. For the security services, the problem lies in tracking the evolving profile of the militants: young, male, often British Pakistani, sometimes middle class, sometimes from the margins of society, only one thing is sure. "The nightmare scenario does not come from overseas," said one Whitehall security source earlier this week. "It's at home."

MI5 says Britain has become the most targeted country in the world for several reasons. The primary among them is that it is a lot more accessible than America. So militants who would like to strike the US, but cannot obtain visas or are otherwise kept out, turn their attention to the UK. The other major reason is, the staunch support

offered by former prime minister Tony Blair to Washington has pushed Britain up the target list. "Before 2001, the UK was barely mentioned by militants, though there was a threat. That threat increased between 2001 and 2003, but got a major boost from the war in Iraq. It has not dropped away since," said one official. At the Foreign Office, strategists have been working to counter the damage done to Britain's image in the Middle East, south Asia and more generally, among the world's Muslims. Late last year, advisers recommended that Blair and his ministers drop all mention of "the War on Terror"—something Gordon Brown, who succeeded Blair last month, has now done. But there is much ground to be covered. "Britain's image as an honest broker in the Muslim world is ancient history," said one Western diplomat based in the Middle East.

There is also work to be done at home. Many British Muslims, who are often poorer and less successful in school than other ethnic or religious minorities, have been alienated by the talk of 'communities' within Britain and by the wars in Iraq and Afghanistan. Blair's refusal to call for a ceasefire during the war in Lebanon last year angered many. In addition, intelligence officers say Britain has a particular

from that of the 7/7 bombers.

A second, unrelated plot was uncovered in the UK's capital last year, centering on a group of friends who had come together in mosques in the northeastern suburb of Walthamstow. Yet to come to trial, the young British-Pakistanis are alleged to have plotted to bring down three or even six trans-atlantic jets by concocting explosives

THE NUMBERS

1,600

identified as potential suicide bombers

1.5 million

Muslims have made the UK their home

32 per cent

are of Pakistani origin and 7 per cent of Indian

700

is the number of madrasas in the UK